

A BLUE MIRAGE

The John Hancock Tower shimmers in the sun, mirroring the old and new in Boston, aloof and cool. It's a star of the city's architecture, both loved and hated.

By Robert Campbell

Every year I poll my class at Harvard on the buildings they like best and least in Boston. (The students are people interested in architecture, not professional architects.) Consistently, the John Hancock Tower has finished first under "best liked" and second (to the Prudential Center) under "least liked." This suggests there isn't a simple answer about the Hancock.

Of all Boston's buildings, it probably is now the most prominent in people's consciousness of their city — no small achievement in a town that boasts Kallmann and McKinnell's Boston City Hall, H. H. Richardson's Trinity Church, Charles McKim's Boston Public Library, and Charles Bulfinch's State House.

Maybe it isn't quite the right achievement, though, for a building that its architect intended to be, so far as possible, a quiet backdrop to its prominent neighbors, Trinity Church and Copley Square.

The Hancock's birth, like that of many heroes, was swathed in controversy. As Pharaoh did to Moses, so the Boston Society of Architects did to the Hancock: It tried to kill the building at its inception. "We had hoped," the BSA announced in 1967, "in this time of urban unrest, for something other than an egotistical monument."

Edward Logue, czar of Boston's renewal program at that time, called the proposed design "an outrage." John Burchard, dean of humanities at MIT, thought it was "a monster."

After it was built, however, the American Institute of Architects gave the tower its highest national award for good design. And Charles Jencks, a well-known critic, called it "a late-modern masterpiece."

No one is more alert to the Hancock's contradictions than its architect. And no one states them better.

Henry Cobb, a founding partner of



the architectural firm of I. M. Pei and Partners, is now also chairman of the Department of Architecture at Harvard. Cobb designed the Hancock Tower in one intense burst of effort in the last two weeks of September 1967.

Thirteen years later, Cobb sees his design this way: "The strength of the building as well as its limitation is the fact that it is so single-minded. It's impoverished because of its single-mindedness, but this also is its drama. It dramatizes the predicament of this enormous thing happening in that place. And I find that, for me, dramatizing the predicament is perhaps as legitimate a role for architecture as solving the problem."

What the steeple is to a Vermont village, the Hancock is to the whole Boston metropolitan area.

On a clear day you can see it from New Hampshire and from Worcester. It signals presence, magnetizes space, punctuates the sky.

Together with its neighbor, the Pru, it makes a double semaphore visible from nearly everywhere. It helps you judge where you are in the metropolis and how far you are from the center. Many Boston neighborhoods, once isolated visually, now have this common landmark, which helps them sense themselves as part of the larger urban whole.

The great blue tower is breathtakingly beautiful at a distance. From Cambridge, across the water, you see the narrow end, split top to bottom by the dark notch that transforms the building into a pair of glittering blades. At nightfall, the red ball of the setting sun is trapped between the blades.

The glass surface changes with every whim of light. It is like a theater scrim: either transparent or opaque depending on how it's lit. When opaque, it can be a mirror, clear, gridded, reflecting, and measuring its surroundings like an instrument of calibration. Or it can be a vague, watery, undefined veil, ever-changing in tone.

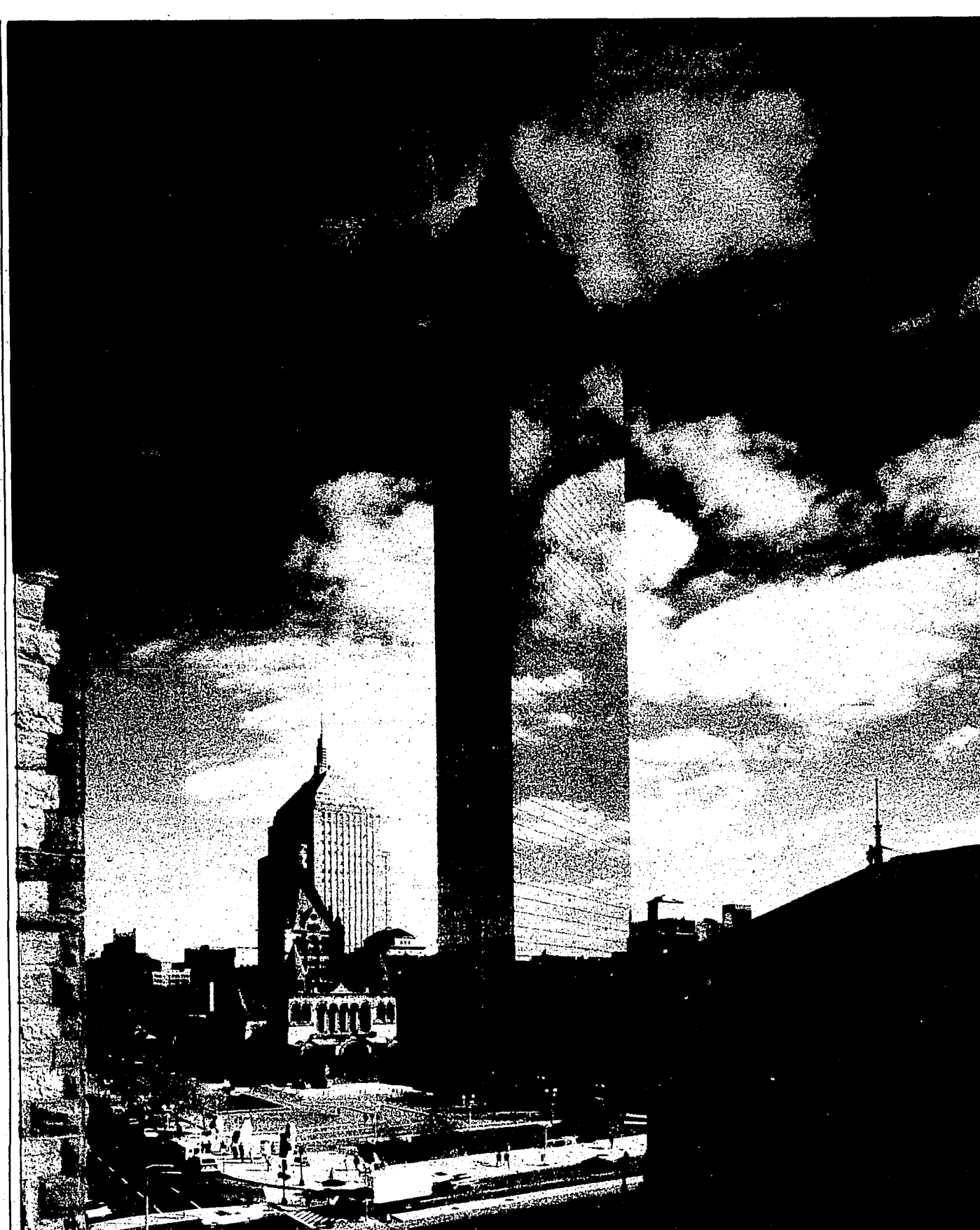
The Hancock was designed by taking things away, not by creating them. Gone is detail, gone is mass, to be replaced by pure, weightless volume. Even volume disappears from many viewpoints and the Hancock shrinks to mere surface, one 790-foot mirror balanced on its edge. It is hard to imagine it filled with desks.

Everyone notices the angle. The tower angles away from its street grid, filling out its site only at the lowest few floors. The angling does several things. It creates an entrance plaza that focuses on Trinity Church and presents the thinnest, least overwhelming side to Copley Square.

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ROBERT CAMPBELL, A PRACTICING ARCHITECT IN CAMBRIDGE, IS THE GLOBE'S ARCHITECTURE CRITIC.

The shape
of the John
Hancock
Tower, says
its designer,
was a
response to
its neighbors
in Copley
Square.



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And it aligns the tower with Huntington and other streets a few blocks away, a device intended to make the tower a kind of formal link between the two parts of the city.

For years, Henry Cobb has used a slide lecture to explain his building's strange shape. The Hancock, Cobb says, is a "contingent" building, meaning that its shape is a response to its surroundings. He contrasts it with what he calls "autonomous" buildings, like the Prudential, whose shape is generated only by the building's internal needs. The Pru could be anywhere; the Hancock could only be where it is.

"Our concern for the relationship to Trinity Church and Copley Square preempted all other issues," Cobb continues. "It seems to me that everything about the building betrays the fact that we were terribly concerned with the surroundings. We positioned and shaped the tower to make the church the autonomous center and the tower the contingent satellite."

Not everyone is persuaded by Cobb's argument. One thing, however, is surely true. The angling of the tower makes it appear to be taking up some kind of stance, striking an attitude, making some unexplained gesture instead of simply filling up its air space. That sense of gesture is crucial to its appeal.

Next to its beauty, what strikes you about the Hancock is its arctic silence. It tells you *nothing*.

Compare it, for instance, to that other most remarkable Boston building of its period, City Hall. City Hall turns itself inside out, practically spilling its guts all over its plaza to tell you about itself. You can see how it's held up, what it's made of, where to enter. If you know how to read it, you can identify the mayor's suite, the council chamber, the office floors, the public services. City Hall can't really be said to have a surface at all, but instead is a visible skeleton and set of organs.

In contrast, the Hancock is all skin, all silence. No orifice suggests that there is someone inside looking out. Instead, the building is blind, with a fixed glassy stare that reminds you of the discomfort of trying to hold a conversation with a person wearing mirror sunglasses. The blind stare never blinks. At roof, at lobby, at observatory, at executive floor, there is no change of expression. There is no

bottom, middle, or top, no head in the air, no foot on the ground. Nothing breaks into the surface, nothing emerges from it.

Where the great mirror meets the ground, a thin slot framed in metal wraps it like a microscopic moat. The slot makes the building, in Henry Cobb's phrase, seem to have "slipped up from below." It doesn't rest on its plaza but slides weightlessly, silently through. It is spiritual, not carnal, in its refusal to touch.

The Hancock doesn't like to be close. And people don't like to be close to the Hancock. Approach too near, and the elegant panels grow huge and rejecting.

Going to the Hancock,

you move as in a Nordic fable, hurrying through wind over a dark surface toward a building that in Cobb's own words "does not invite entry." Even the huge lobby is hidden from view by the reflective glass.

Of this depressing approach Cobb says: "We never wanted an ornamental plaza. We wanted a surface. Just building, surface, church."

The entrance is an aesthetic problem in itself. How can you penetrate a sixty-three-story mirror? The solution was a row of plexiglass bubble canopies — additions to, rather than violations of, the perfect surface. The domes broke last winter through a combination of fatigue, wind, and cold. Now Cobb has de-

signed a new entrance canopy, a single continuous skylit shed shape that is to rest on the round frames of the former bubbles.

"The original domes," Cobb says, "were in a slightly facetious spirit that was at odds with what is a very austere statement, like somebody giggling at a funeral." Ideally, he says, joking wistfully, you should enter the tower by walking down the nave of Trinity Church, descending an escalator at the altar, and traversing underground to rise again within the inviolable tower.

There is an aesthetic war in progress between the cool Hancock and its

human occupants. As an employee, once you reach a certain pay grade, you can order your own furniture from the company's purchasing department. Most people choose traditional styles, which result in little nests of Spanish provincial, like warm campsites scattered across the tundra of the glass tower.

On the bosses' floor, the fifty-ninth, these discords reach the level of surrealism. Leaving the elevators, you turn to see a guard at a desk at the end of a stark tunnel of space. You see nothing else. The guard, it turns out, is the sole occupant of a reception hall nearly two hundred feet long. There are only eight executives, with their aides,

on this entire thirty-thousand square-foot floor. Each has his own bathroom with marble floor, walls, and sink.

On fifty-nine, symbols tend to substitute for personality. The desk on which the first Hancock policy was written is displayed as if in a museum. So is John Hancock's wall-paper. But at seven hundred feet above the city, shorn of their connections with the past or with current use, such objects have little meaning. They are mere collectibles on the corporate mantelpiece.

The Hancock may or may not be a "contingent" building, but it most certainly is an autonomous place socially.

The glass skin seals the interior off from the world around it as tightly as an incubation ward. Within this germ-free bubble, something like eighteen grades of employees can choose to eat, bank, rest, and shop where they work. There are three cafeterias, delicately adjusted in rank, that ascend the social scale as they rise in actual height from the basement to the third floor to the fifty-ninth. One of the arguments made to justify the Hancock originally was that it would keep the employees and their buying power downtown. Some do shop in Back Bay, of course, but they don't have to. The building is as self-contained as the ocean liner it in some way resembles.

No one will talk for the record about the windows. A legal suit of epic proportions is still slouching toward some courtroom somewhere.

Despite the secrecy, it is possible to imagine the causes of the Hancock disaster. The conclusions that follow are my own, not necessarily based on unimpeachable sources, and perhaps subject to error.

The Hancock had four separate and, in principle at least, unrelated technical disasters during construction.

The first was an excavation problem. The excavation for the building disturbed water tables and earth pressures around it. Trinity Church and the Copley Plaza Hotel, which are built on wood piles sunk into the filled land of the former Back Bay mud flat, settled and suffered damage. So did utility lines. All this was before the tower was even built. The Hancock itself rests on three thousand steel piles and never sank.

The second problem, the famous one, was the window breakage. Windows broke during construction by the hundreds. This was a problem primarily within the double-pane reflective glass unit itself. However, since all parts of any building interact, it may also have been related to building movement or to the detailing or to the large size of the windows. The problem was solved by the removal and replacement of all 10,344 windows, each weighing five hundred pounds, at a cost of \$6 million.

The third problem was building movement — wind

sway — which, it was thought, might prove uncomfortable to the occupants. This was addressed at a cost of \$3 million by the installation of large so-called tuned mass dampers on the fifty-eighth floor. They are three-hundred-ton weights at opposite ends of the tower that slide on beds of oil whenever the building moves in the wind, to counteract its motion.

The fourth and in many ways most interesting problem was the danger that the building might actually overturn. This was an unexpected discovery. Because of its window breakage, the Hancock became the most closely studied building of all time. Unexpectedly, the observations led to the conclusion that the Hancock was in remote but statistically possible danger of literally tilting to the point of collapse along its long (not short) axis in the event of certain theoretically possible winds. As a result, its stiffness was increased by the addition of fifteen hundred tons of steel bracing. Perhaps the dampers helped here, too. National structural engineering standards, with which the Hancock design had complied, were also revised as a result.

The final verdict isn't in on the Hancock. And indeed, perhaps one doesn't make a judgment on a work that has passed into myth.

I don't think the Hancock really succeeds in what its architect most wanted, which was that it be a "contingent" building. It's just too big a tail to be wagged by Trinity Church.

But it was Henry Cobb's wish to make the Hancock "contingent" that led Cobb to his unique and wonderful form. Art sometimes needs premises that don't bear full examination ■